

the West Midnapore belt, the stronghold of the Santhals and other tribals. This will come into effect from the coming academic session in 1,600 schools against the 300-odd as of now. New textbooks are being written and teachers are being appointed. There's more in store for the tribals. Bhattacharya's Government will buy the entire supply of kendu leaves from them and do away with the go-between mahajans. "Even if it means losses for the state Government, we are determined not to allow tribals to suffer monetary losses and their work go in vain," Bhattacharya said. He has also hiked the allowances of daily wagers at Murshidabad in north Bengal.

The mood of change is visible in the state capital as well. With an eye on the corporation elections next year, Kolkata Mayor Bikash Ranjan Bhattacharya is tightening the screws. He wants municipal employees to be punctual and has threatened to put promotions on the backburner if they are found lagging. Bikash also recently inaugurated a 50-km tree planting project in the city, which will be undertaken by the municipal corporation. Apart from that—given the number of accidents and fires in markets in the past years—the corporation will import two top-class modernised hazardous materials vans from Europe and Japan. The vehicles are fully-equipped, state-of-the-art fire stations on wheels and will cost Rs 5 crore. Also on the anvil are 1,900 new buses to ease the problems of local commuters. The growing number of road accidents are also a cause for concern for the Left Government; a high-powered committee headed by a former chief secretary will be set up to look into ways on how to make roads safer.

Bhattacharya doesn't seem satisfied with just these sops. The most important public relations exercise that the state Government has taken up is to sell potatoes at Rs 13 per kg against the peak of Rs 19 after it was caught



AFTER THE LALGARH FIASCO, THE CPM KNOWS THAT IT WILL HAVE TO WOO ITS TRADITIONAL TRIBAL VOTEBANK AFRESH.

dragging its feet over the spiralling prices of essential commodities. The cheaper potatoes, called Jyoti and a brainchild of state Finance Minister Asim Dasgupta, are being sold at 13 outlets in Kolkata and will soon be extended to other districts. Cheaper onions and edible oils will soon follow.

All that may not be so easy to implement with the Trinamool Congress raring to go. Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly, Partha Chatterjee has questioned the move, saying that it is not clear why the Government had not implemented the West Bengal Cold Storage Act (Licensing and Regulating) 1966 when prices had shown trends of heading north as early as last October. "The Government had no

intentions to check its own hoarders who run the cold storages. Now that the situation has gone out of hand, they are trying damage control measures," he says. Dasgupta, the prime mover behind the Government's action on cheaper essential commodities, says a notification against hoarders will be issued soon. Meanwhile, there are talks within the Government to amend the Essential Commodities Act to bring potatoes and edibles like sugar and oil under the ambit of the law.

With the Assembly polls two years away, the Left Front seems to be getting its act together already lest the Trinamool Congress rides further on the popularity wave it harnessed in the last Lok Sabha polls. ■